

Casteless Policies

It was meant to be by Dalits, of Dalits, for Dalits. But the Mayawati Government has something for everyone.

FOR THE WEAKER SECTIONS OF THE SOCIETY: Mayawati's Government has decided to grant 10 per cent reservation to SCs, STs and the OBCs. The reservations have also been extended to the minorities and the economically weaker sections of the upper castes. The projects will be undertaken in public-private partnerships with private entities being able to avail benefits in the form of land or grants from the Government. It will also provide 16 lakh homeless SCs and STs houses at subsidised rates under the Mahamaya Housing Scheme.

FOR POWER GENERATION: Her Government has given a commitment to take the state's power generation capacity—hovering around 4,000 MW since the past 60 years—to 10,000 MW in the next five years. It has decided to allocate Rs 1,900 crore each to Paricha Extension Thermal Power Project as well as Harduvaganj Extension Thermal Power Project, which will produce 500 MW electricity each. Money will also be provided to several other thermal power projects soon. It has also signed an MoU with NTPC and the UP Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Limited to establish and operate the 1,320-MW Meja Power Station.

FOR INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT: The Uttar Pradesh Government has embarked upon an ambitious project of constructing the 1,047-km-long Ganga Expressway. The project will cost the state exchequer at least Rs 40,000 crore. The expressway will run from Noida to Varanasi-Balia. With the completion of this project, the time taken to reach the eastern part of the state from Delhi will be reduced to just eight hours compared to the 24 hours it takes today.

FOR THE TAX SYSTEM: The Value-Added Tax (VAT) has already been made effective in the state from January 1. This was done to improve the trade tax structure qualitatively and check tax evasion.

FOR THE FARMERS: The Government has raised the minimum rate of daily agriculture and allied wages to Rs 100 from Rs 58. The old age/kisan pension has also been raised from Rs 150 to Rs 300 per month.

FOR POLICING: The Uttar Pradesh Government aims to set up an anti-terrorist squad and a Special Investigation Team to handle sensitive cases of crime and corruption.

FOR THE UNEMPLOYED: Mayawati has plans to generate employment for one lakh sanitation workers in every revenue village. She also aims to recruit at least 88,000 primary teachers during her tenure.



is absolute. Her appeal is no longer regional: her fan club constitutes almost 10 per cent of Indian voters. Who else can boast of such singular star appeal across the nation? She may be the Great Helmswoman of Dalits, and her electoral achievement greater than what Ambedkar or Jagjivan Ram or her mentor Kanshi Ram could do in their lifetime, but she refuses to be trapped in her own identity. She wants to be inclusive in her own way. Gone is the Mayawati of the "tilak, taraju aur talwar/maro inko jute char" era. Brahmins, baniyas and thakurs are unlikely to get such a treatment in Mayadom. The Manuvadi tirade is no longer in vogue. Brahmins, Muslims, traders...all are welcome. The social base is expanding, and there is a slogan to match: *sarvajan hitaya/sarvajan sukhai*. Earlier it was "bahun hitaya/bahun sukhai." The sociology of Mayawati cannot be straitjacketed. It is reflected within her own party. Satish Mishra, confidant and chief social engineer, is the Brahmin face of the party. Akhilesh Das, a defector from the Congress and a former minister at the Centre, represents the Baniyas. Akbar Ahmed and